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Github Link: https://github.com/sdass3/econ238-portfolio

Part 1: The Islands and the Whales

#1

- The first main property-rights debate is whether Faroese whalers should be allowed to hunt whales. In other words, the property right concerns the fate of the whales
- Mmany Faroese people in the film still participate in the hunt, international marine activists are trying to stop it because they believe whales should be protected.
- Whaling is deeply embedded in Faroese culture, which makes the issue more complicated.
- Whales are a common-access resource:
    a. People cannot easily be excluded from accessing them.
    b. They are rivalrous because once one person hunts and kills a whale, that whale cannot be hunted again.

#2

- The Faroese people and their culture depend on whales for survival, whether as a food source or as part of their livelihood. This creates an incentive to preserve the population.
- In the documentary, older members of the community mention several times that whale meat is not eaten as frequently as it was in the past. This suggests that some preservation may already be happening.
- During the press conference with activists, one Faroese person asks, "Are you going to deliver us beef from the other side of the world?"
    i. I think alternative food sources could reduce the number of whales killed and eaten, potentially lowering mercury exposure.
    ii. However, whale meat is deeply embedded in Faroese culture. People are not eating it solely for its taste or nutritional benefits, but also for nostalgia and community.
    iii. I am sure alternatives have been proposed, but I do not think they would necessarily be accepted. I am also unsure whether they would be operationally realistic.
- The Faroese system is an example of Elinor Ostrom's common-access resource management in practice:
    iv. There are established traditions and rules surrounding whaling.
    v. The community shares responsibility for preserving the resource.

vi. People understand that overhunting by one individual would hurt everyone.
vii. Outside pressures, such as activists or international regulations, could disrupt this balance. They might even cause the Faroese to eat more whale to assert their national identity, or make younger generations less interested in the tradition.
viii. I find Ostrom's approach consistent with this example because communities can establish their own boundaries and rules. This does not mean property rights are unnecessary.

#3 Discussion questions

- The film places a lot of emphasis on capturing, killing, and eating puffins (which I still don't understand why). Why or why not can puffins not be used as a substitute for whales?
- Who bears the cost of pollution? If mercury contamination makes whale meat unsafe to eat, should Faroese families bear the cost of losing a traditional and abundant food source, or should outside governments be responsible for providing alternatives?
- Distribution of risk: If some families rely more heavily on whale meat than others, are they more likely to be exposed to mercury poisoning? Should health policies account for differences in income and access to alternative foods?
- Defining what is sustainable and right: If activists believe the whale hunts are unethical or environmentally harmful, while Faroese residents believe their traditional practices are sustainable, whose definition should influence policy?
- Externalities: What negative externalities can activists like the ones in the documentary, have on the whales and the local community

#4

- I believe the Faroese people have a right to maintain their traditions.
- Although many people in the documentary have concerning mercury levels, it was also clear that some do not particularly care about the health risks.
- I am mainly thinking of the father of the two girls, whose mercury levels were significantly high. He was sarcastic throughout the documentary and even tried to rationalize his consumption by saying that he does not eat whale more often, but simply eats more of it when he does.
- It is the Faroese people's right to eat what they want, regardless of the health risks. Outsiders do not have the authority to dictate their traditions.
- However, the responsibility to maintain this tradition safely belongs to the Faroese themselves.

- If they choose to continue eating something that may be harmful after being informed of the risks, they should be responsible for making that choice.
- In my opinion, our obligations are to educate when necessary and respect other people's choices. Beyond that, our options are limited.

#5

- Non-point source pollution is difficult to manage because it is hard to isolate a single source. There can be many contributing causes, and mercury can accumulate over time, especially in whales.
- Property-rights systems or governance agreements could help internalize these costs, but they would be difficult to apply in this situation.
- Possible solutions include:
    - Pollution taxes
    - International agreements to limit emissions
- However, when the ocean and air is effected, establishing and enforcing property rights is extremely difficult. It is hard to draw boundaries on those

#6

- After watching the documentary, I am much more sympathetic to the Faroese people, although I do not necessarily agree with their continued consumption of whale meat.
- Seeing people across different generations unite over a food that is so deeply embedded in their culture makes their tradition difficult to oppose.
- International organizations can:
    - Provide scientific research.
    - Establish conservation standards.
    - Pressure governments to protect wildlife.
- For example, the Faroese could receive financial support for maintaining traditional food practices or community stewardship while reducing unsustainable hunting.
- Efficiency should account for more than economic output. It should also consider environmental damage, public health, cultural identity, and long-term sustainability.

#7

- I might expect fertility rates to be higher because living on a small, isolated island can offer benefits compared to living in a large city.
- The Faroe Islands appear to be a very community- and family-oriented place. Being surrounded by friends and family might encourage people to have children.
- There may also be an incentive to have children who could eventually take over a family business.

- I would attribute declining fertility and population to younger Faroese people leaving the islands.
- In the age of the internet and social media, younger generations may be more likely to leave and explore opportunities elsewhere.
- This could also put whaling at risk because the people who are supposed to carry on the tradition are leaving.

#8

- I am unsure whether this is primarily a social trend or a labor-market trend for Faroese women who leave.
- When there are limited opportunities in a location, people often move elsewhere to find work.
- Faroese men pursuing women abroad may be a response to the effects of the local labor market.
- However, I do not agree with treating foreign women as resources rather than human beings.
- This reflects a broader global trend in which people move in response to wages, opportunities, and quality of life.
- Given how remote and close-knit the Faroese community is, I could see this trend continuing to bring foreign women to the islands for marriage while also creating social divisions and challenges with integration.

#9

- I am not surprised that fish sales did not decline after Russia stopped buying from the Faroe Islands.
- Fish is a commodity, meaning it is a relatively interchangeable raw material. The Faroe Islands can redirect its exports to another country.
- The Faroese economy is relatively protected against volatility for two reasons:
    - Potential support from Denmark.
    - The fact that many of its exports are fish-related, meaning there are likely to be buyers in other countries.
- Rochester has already learned the importance of not relying too heavily on a small number of employers, as it did with companies like Xerox and Kodak.
- Concentrating economic activity among a few employers creates significant risk.

#10

- I think the Faroese infrastructure system is sustainable, but only for a small island community of that size.

- Subsidized transportation makes jobs, schools, healthcare, and entertainment easier to access.
- When locals attend activities and pay for them, that money can circulate back into the local economy.
- Overall, the infrastructure helps connect the different communities across the Faroe Islands.
- However, I am unsure whether building and maintaining this infrastructure is financially or environmentally sustainable.
- Without subsidies, locals would pay much more out of pocket for transportation. They might travel less often, increasing the isolation of communities.
- Connecting communities allows people to work together more effectively and build a stronger economy.

#11

- My guess is that the Faroe Islands does not have a McDonald's because of the article's observation that it is already a nice place and has little desire to optimize, become more efficient, or exploit resources to become even "nicer."
- To me, becoming "nicer" means modernizing and becoming more like the Western world, including introducing more franchises.
- I think wealthy countries have the capacity to say "enough," but this would require becoming less reliant on imports and exports.
- These countries could learn from the Faroe Islands by emphasizing quality of life rather than constant expansion and franchising.
- Economic growth does not have to conflict with sustainability. However, the way wealthy countries such as the United States and China pursue growth, and the speed at which they seek it, often comes at the expense of sustainability.

#12

- Regular question and MOAT
    - I am unsure whether much would change if the Faroe Islands had open borders.
    - Without financial incentives or subsidized programs for potential migrants, I think the islands' remote location and language would deter many people from moving there.
    - A small influx of newcomers could potentially introduce more franchises and outside practices.
    - The Faroese might adopt some of these practices without abandoning their traditional values and customs.
    - One thing I do not think would change is whaling:
        i. I doubt many newcomers would adopt the tradition.

    ii. However, based on the documentary, it would be very difficult for the Faroese people themselves to give it up.
- Hometown MOAT: Something very unique to my hometown of Stoneham, Massachusetts is the 9 o'clock horn that goes off twice a day (once in the morning and once at night), and is said to be heard from anywhere in town. While modernization and technology have made horns and other time indicating tools obsolete, the 9 o'clock horn has fought back very well. It is one of the very few symbols Stoneham has as a town; hence why it stays though some new residents might find it disruptive. If the town of Stoneham has any sort of culture, this would be the only bullet on the list. If the MOAT disappears, it'll likely be replaced by what we currently have, handheld modern technology. After writing my answer to this question, I understand the Faroese and whaling significantly better,
- Rochester MOAT: See other part of Blackboard submission or github

#13

Attended discussion session on 11/06. Spoke about how in the documentary, whaling and eating whale was so deeply embedded in the Faroese cultural even educating people would not deter them. So at that point, countries shouldn't have to pay reparations if it continues willingly.